Here they found that their colleagues had also been hard at work in their absence: Broadfoot's sappers had placed charges in the spandrels of the great Char Chatta covered bazaar, originally built during the reign of Shah Jahan and renowned not just as one of the supreme wonders of Mughal architecture but as one of the greatest buildings in all Central Asia. The superb structure with its painted wooden vaulting and intricate tilework, said by some to be the single most beautiful building in Afghanistan, had been chosen for destruction by Pollock, for it was here that Macnaghten's body had been displayed on a butcher's hook for public humiliation. For Mirza 'Ata the destruction was but another sign of British duplicity and weakness: 'After entering Kabul, the English demolished with their cannon all the larger buildings of the city, including the lovely four-roofed market, in revenge for Macnaghten. As the proverb says "When you're not strong enough to punish the camel, then go and beat the basket carried by the donkey!"'[93] It was one of the many ironies of the war that while British interest in promoting commerce between India and Afghanistan had been one of the original motives for sending Burnes on his first trip up the Indus, the final act of the whole catastrophic saga was the vindictive demolition of the main commercial centre of the region.[94] The much vaunted Indus Navigation Scheme had of course come to nothing; and now, before the British retired behind the Sutlej, the largest market in Central Asia was to be reduced to rubble.

The dynamiting of the great bazaar unleashed in Kabul a wave of rape, pillage and murder similar to that which had destroyed Istalif. 'Soldiers and camp-followers from both [Jalalabad and Kandahar] camps are plundering the town,' wrote Chamberlain on his return on 7 October. 'Here and there the smoke rising in black clouds showed that the firebrand had been applied to some chief's house . . . Part of the town also on fire.'[95] There was nothing accidental about the blaze. 'After we had been in Kabul about a fortnight,' Lieutenant Greenwood recorded in his diary,

> [we] were ordered one evening to be in readiness to march the following day into the city. The object was not stated, but we could form a pretty good idea of what we were to do, and our expectations were correct. We proceeded the next morning, and blew up all the principal chowks and bazaars, and set fire to the city in many places. The houses were of course gutted in a very short time, and bales of cloth, muslins, fur cloaks, blankets and wearing apparel of every description were turned out and destroyed . . . Some of the men found a number of English cases of hermetically sealed grouse, and other meats, on which, as may be imagined, they had a fine feast . . .